

Contemporary Sociological Thinkers and Theories



Sandro Segre

CONTEMPORARY SOCIOLOGICAL THINKERS AND THEORIES

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Foreword

This work aims to introduce to a public of scholars and doctoral students some authors and theoretical perspectives, which are apparently among the most influential on contemporary social theory. The definition of the concept of theory and social theory in particular is debatable, possibly because of its “enormous diverse and multifaceted” aspects (Calhoun et al. 2002: 19). Students of social theory have often stressed both similarities and differences between the conceptions of theory in the natural and the social sciences. The conception of theory and of social theory in particular, as will be here abided by, will accord with a conventional one. Theories, both in the social and the natural sciences, if conventionally defined aim to formulate systematic, abstract and general statements that are induced from empirical reality. All theoretical statements “transcend the particular and the time bound” and attempt to explain empirical events for the present times in abstract, non-evaluative and formal terms (Turner 1998: 2).

Theory, in this sense, purposes to be scientific in that statements aim at prediction and explanation of phenomena, and generating new research hypotheses (Ritzer 2000: 4). Emphasis has also been given here, as other authors have done, to the conflicting and incompatible views on its nature and presuppositions, which characterize social theory and sociology in particular (cf. Alexander 1982: 1–5; 1987: 1–21; Joas and Knöbl 2009: 5–12; Baert and Carreira da Silva 2010: 1; Seidman 2013: 2–5). Social theory should have a wide range of applications to important social issues. This work, like other works on contemporary social theory, aims to convey essential information on prominent authors and theories, with an emphasis on general theories which may be applied, at least in principle, to several fields of inquiry. It differs from other works on the same subject in many ways, however.

The work, first of all, focuses on contemporary theory only, in keeping to its title. In this respect, it is unlike works on social theory that provide information also on the classical sociological tradition, as especially represented by Marx, Durkheim and Weber (see for example Baert and Carreira da Silva 2010; Seidman 2013). As a further difference, this work gives a conventional definition of social theory in this very foreword, but does not devote a chapter to this theme, as other authors have done (cf. Joas and Knöbl 2009). It does not seek, moreover, to derive from theoretical principles, such as they may be found in past or contemporary sociological theorists, an abstract structure of sociological theory (see Turner 1982, 1998). It also makes no attempt to distinguish between micro and macro theoretical approaches, as this distinction has been variously interpreted, and has been found controversial (Collins 1988: ch. 11).

Given the present limitations of space and time, finally, this work does not deal with some directions, both old and new, of contemporary sociological theory. It does not deal, in particular, with Critical Theory, Cultural Studies, Expectations States Theory, Feminist Social Theory, Globalization, Theories of Consumption, and World System Analysis. Also, major contemporary authors such as Bauman and Elias have not been considered here, while the presentation of actor-network theory has been confined to a brief note at the end of the chapter on network theory. It is hoped that these lacunae will be remedied in the future. The work has been given a modular structure, to the effect that readers may choose those chapters and perspectives they find most proximate to their interests. Each chapter contains a rather detailed introduction to a perspective or author. The chapters are of different lengths, but there are no book-length chapters. All of them are divided in several sub-chapters according to the particular themes, in which a particular perspective or the thought of a given author are articulated.

Each chapter, furthermore, contains in its final part information on the current reception of that perspective or author. Any selection of the relevant contributions to social theory is inevitably affected by the author's orientations and preferences; still, an effort has been made keep to a presentation unbiased by pre-conceived ideological orientations. Several selection criteria of the secondary literature have been used, such as the reviewers' scholarly reputation; the notoriety of their evaluation, whether positive or negative; and the extent to which they cover different aspects of a perspective or of the constitutive elements of an author's thought.

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Chapter 1

The Neofunctionalism of Jeffrey Alexander

Preliminary Remarks

Jeffrey Alexander's (1947–) reputation as a sociology theoretician is considerable both in the United States and in Europe. Alexander received his university education in the United States, first at Harvard, where, during the 1960s, he had the opportunity to study Marx, Weber, Durkheim, and Parsons in depth. Then he continued his studies at the University of California, Berkeley, where he graduated with a thesis on Parsons. After a first teaching period spent in Los Angeles at the University of California, he is currently teaching at Yale University (Alexander 1998a: 8–10). Alexander is an outstanding representative of the neofunctionalist perspective he personally contributed to formulate, and is well known among sociology theoreticians for his epistemological orientation, which he calls “strong program.”¹

The Neofunctionalist Perspective and the “Strong Program”

The neofunctionalist perspective ensues from the discredit of the functionalist approach, especially in Parsons' formulation, which the neofunctionalist perspective intends to reformulate. This perspective draws on several elements of Parsons' theory: the distinction among personality, culture and society; a systematic analysis of the relations existing between culture and society; and differentiation as an essential characteristic of social change (see Joas and Knöbl 2008: 336). Alexander and other representatives of this perspective have charged functionalism with several criticisms, as follows: it contains conservatively oriented and unverifiable ideological assumptions; it presents the social actors as culturally determined, and consequently, not introducing the element of contingency in their theory of social order; it underestimates the relevance of social conflict and change; and it does not sufficiently distinguish between an abstract notion of equilibrium, which may prove useful as an analytical concept, and equilibrium as a condition of really existing societies.

The neofunctionalist program, in the formulation given by Alexander (who mentions in this regard also some other authors, especially Luhmann), has tried to make up for these deficiencies in different ways. The voluntaristic, symbolic and contingent aspects of action, as enunciated by Parsons but not sufficiently considered in his theory, have been taken into greater account. Greater importance has been attached to elements of strain and conflict, considered inherent in society, rather than to equilibrium and social integration factors. Different interpretations of Weber and Durkheim from those formulated by Parsons have been proposed. Greater attention has been paid to Marx's epistemological teachings and to the micro-sociological theoretical schools of thought. The neofunctionalist program of studies and research includes, in Alexander's opinion, a new definition and conceptualization of the relations between culture and society, in which no integration is assumed (as Parsons does). Instead, the elements of tension existing both among subcultures, and between the social and the cultural system, are carefully considered.

Furthermore, the neofunctionalist program involves a critical reinterpretation of Parsons' contributions which does not intend to reiterate Parsons' fundamental error. According to Parsons (in Alexander's opinion), the normative elements of social reality have ultimately greater importance than instrumental elements (Alexander 1983b: 272). This critical reinterpretation is focused on social change (the contingent aspects and the possible dysfunctional consequences of which are particularly stressed), political sociology (Parsons' arguments about the stability of the democratic system are questioned) and profession sociology (the conflicting relations existing within single professions and among different professions, and the importance of

1 Alexander has also authored, with Kenneth Thompson, *A Contemporary Introduction to Sociology* (see Alexander and Thompson 2008).

particular interests in professionals' behaviors are highlighted) (Alexander 1984: 21–3; 1985a, 1998a: 216–28; Alexander and Colomy 1990: 44–55; 1998: 65–76; 2004: 207–208). This neofunctionalist program of studies is “multidimensional,” in the sense that it intends to provide non-reductionist descriptions, explanations and interpretations of social life in relation to the problems of action and social order.

Conversely a reductionist program explains these problems, whether referring to conditions that are external to the actors and cannot be changed by them, or only to internal conditions, such as interiorized social norms, but not to both kinds of conditions at the same time. The “strong program” claims the autonomy of culture from any social determination, and involves consequently a new way to carry out sociological investigations. It conceives action as the product of actors' voluntary commitment to achieve goals or put moral norms into effect; but at the same time, action is constrained or affected by an external environment. This epistemological program concerns social sciences as a whole, without making distinctions among different disciplines, and demands to be systematically referred to the subjective meanings, which the actors, whether individually or collectively, give to reality, and to pay attention to the constraints the actors meet with in their social life.

Cultural products, which originate from the scientific community a scholar belongs to, are included in this program of studies. Investigations conforming to the “strong program” move from the epistemological assumption that knowledge produced within the sphere of social sciences – in the sense of understanding and explaining social reality – requires a particular interpretation of cultural phenomena. This interpretation should highlight that cultural phenomena are socially produced; they are, however, not determined by the social structure and, in general, by the contents and the meanings of social life. Cultural phenomena have therefore their own autonomy toward such meanings and contents. It is assumed that culture itself shapes social life, and forms an environment that is internal to the actor, and analytically distinguished from it.

The “strong program” attaches great relevance to meanings, symbols, narratives, beliefs and ideologies, collective representations, and in general, to the cultural aspects of social life. The “strong program” seeks to interpret and reconstruct the details of the constitutive elements of culture by identifying its individual and collective actors, and taking into account the hierarchies and the social institutions that mediate the relation between actors and culture. A methodology conforming to the “strong” program involves a set of procedural practices. There is, in the first place, an identification of the relevant social actors. A careful and thick description, a reconstruction and interpretation of the meanings to be attributed to a particular set of relations, and an investigation of the social consequences that directly come from those meanings, are also necessary.

In other words, a causal investigation seeks to highlight the immediate cultural causes of events that occur in the social world, based on a careful and detailed reconstruction of the culturally mediated meanings the actors give to their actions and experiences in those particular circumstances. Social causes, or causes relating to the social structure, which are emphasized by weak programs, have only an indirect relevance for the “strong program,” in the sense of subjecting the symbolic-cultural structures to continuous pressures and changes with particular and historically contingent results (Alexander 1982a: 65–7; 1987: 11–15; 1988b: 36; 1990: 25–6; 1998a: 214–18; 2005; Alexander and Smith 2003: 12–14; Cordero et al. 2008). We shall focus in this chapter on this multidimensional orientation, and on the theoretical and empirical research which Alexander has conducted in keeping with this approach. The theme of collective representations, on which the author has dwelt in his latest works, will be also considered (Alexander 2004, 2009). Finally, we shall provide some information on the reception of his work.²

“Strong Program,” Cultural Sociology, and Post-Positivism

If by culture is meant a system of significant symbols, its sociological study, called “Cultural Sociology” has been pursued by Alexander keeping to the “strong” program. An effort is made to keep explicit the distinction between analyses placed at different levels of generality or abstraction. Alexander makes a distinction between these different levels. Presuppositions are placed at the highest generality level. They

² Introductions to Alexander's sociological thought can be found in Camarda 1992; Cisneros and Pérez Fernández del Castillo 2000; Colomy 2005; Colomy and Turner 1998; Donati 1990.

are assumptions concerning the nature and the meanings of social reality as regards the nature of action and social order, and consequently the opportunities and the constraints actors (whether individuals or communities) meet with by relating with others. Presuppositions are of a metaphysical nature, and therefore cannot be empirically validated, but they contribute to produce theories by inspiring and guiding the notions drawn from the empirical world. They are useful in sociology and in social sciences in general, because they establish their epistemological foundations, in the sense that they point out the general standards of validity for these sciences, and provide them with general principles able to subsume principles deriving from lower analytical levels.

In addition, presuppositions produce in the sphere of social sciences the traditions and the research programs that connote each discipline. To this end, they avail themselves of discourses, or arguments, which establish the standards of truth and validity for each discipline, suggest specific research programs, and aim at persuasion. Presuppositions are relevant for dealing with matters of sociological interest placed at all the different analytical levels. The debate on metaphysical presuppositions is recurring in the social sciences, and distinguishes them from natural sciences. The usefulness of debate consists in pointing out these presuppositions, and in showing the opportunity of changing them, if necessary. Progress in social sciences consists in this, according to Alexander. Social changes involve a theoretical change only if they contribute to produce a reformulation of the metaphysical presuppositions. If shared, metaphysical presuppositions also imply sharing the positions that are situated at a lower analytical level, and therefore close to the empirical world. In contrast to the positivist or empiricist conception, according to which theories are based on objectively verifiable facts (and scientific progress is of a cumulative nature, as it involves the elimination of theories not conforming to empirical results), Alexander recalls the results of the post-positivist reflection on the foundations of knowledge.

Theories are generalized discourses which establish the typical validity standards of a social science. Sociological traditions, ideologies, arguments, explanations and debates, which refer back to disciplinary presuppositions, converge in theories. Therefore, theories have unavoidably a non-empirical origin and nature, though they refer to the empirical world, and claim an objective validity for their propositions. "Facts" – or empirical results – are interpreted according to existing theoretical orientations; theories are often preserved, though there are empirical results incompatible with them, through ancillary hypotheses and the formulation of additional analytical categories. Finally, theoretical changes take place not because of new empirical evidences, but because of the scientists' new epistemological and theoretical orientations.

Differently from positivist epistemology, the post-positivist epistemological approach states the impossibility of any knowledge of the natural or social reality that is not oriented by non-empirical presuppositions. Therefore, it is not sufficient to observe the empirical reality, but it is also necessary to interpret it making use of theoretical knowledge, and to reformulate it taking not only these remarks, but also alternative theories and traditions of thought into account. In the social sciences, the members of the same scientific community must make a "hermeneutic" interpretation, and an effort in mutual understanding, in order to conduct a theoretical investigation. Indeed, only in this way is it possible to make a comparison and establish a dialogue between different research programs and alternative presuppositions. Furthermore, only so does it become possible to explain structures of meaning which escape the control of particular actors (individuals and communities), though they are at the core of power structures. According to Alexander, who adopts a post-positivist epistemological approach, the empirical material highlighted by investigations carried out within the sphere of social sciences not only requires to be understood – it also requires to be interpreted for the public of the members of the same scientific community.

What is empirical takes therefore a symbolic nature, which is essential for its creation, presentation and persuasive capacity before a public of fellow scholars. In general, a symbolic communication made by any actor (whether an individual or a community) in front of any kind of public demands an effective performance and a representation capable of seeming convincing for the public that from time to time is relevant, considering that in modern societies there are a variety of publics for each actor. The success of a collective presentation/performance depends on actors' (i.e. journalists, leaders of social movements, experts) ability to "merge" – so to say – with the texts they perform and with the public with which they communicate. The successful outcome of a presentation/performance, which is proved by the way this public receives and evaluates it, has political consequences because it strengthens or changes actors' power and legitimacy

(Alexander 1982a: 30–33; 1987a: 1–21, 291–301; 1995: 110–23; 2004b; Reed and Alexander 2009: 38, note 8; Cordero et al. 2008: 532–3).

Ideological orientations are situated at a lower and more specific analytical level than presuppositions. Ideological orientations are, in turn, more generalized (in a decreasing order of abstraction and distance from the empirical world) than models, concepts, definitions, classifications, laws, complex and simple theoretical propositions, methodological assumptions, and finally empirical observational statements, which are therefore influenced in their contents by research programs and scientific traditions. The intention is manifold: firstly, to avoid both their conflation, from which overlapping and confusion would result; secondly, to avoid the reductionism, which would derive from using only a single analytical level; and finally to formulate theories, the presuppositions of which are different and incompatible. This incompatibility is illustrated by the theories that adopt individualistic presuppositions, according to which social order is the result of interactions among individuals.

Collectivistic presuppositions, which state that social order pre-exists to individuals, provide a further illustration. In the first case, it is assumed that action involves a double element of interpretation, through which we aim at understanding the world, and strategization, through which we seek to transform it. Meanwhile, we neglect the constraints the actor encounters in the social and cultural system, which build the environments external to action. In the second case, a material or normative coercive character is imputed to this external environment. Individual action would therefore have no autonomy. In either case, theoretical analysis would not be able to include a different analytical level, and consequently, to formulate a general theory of society. Briefly stated, the result is a reduced explanatory capacity. The deficiencies resulting from the influence of the positivist and empiricist epistemology are recurring in natural and social sciences, and have been a hindrance to their progress.

To this epistemological orientation which he considers wrong and misleading, Alexander counters with his approach called “theoretical logic.” “Theoretical logic” is connoted not only by an explicit reference to the key presuppositions for carrying out an empirical research but also by the persuasion that scientific progress develops in virtue of changes occurring in the empirical and the non-empirical world. The latter is connoted by metaphysical and dogmatic presuppositions – which therefore are not subject to assessment – characterizing any scientific thought. “Theoretical logic” deals with the key sociological themes of action and social order considering all the aforementioned levels of abstraction, and keeping to the “multi-dimensional” approach and to the “strong program” of Alexander’s neofunctionalist perspective. The distinction between sociological theories placed at micro and macro analytical levels becomes therefore irrelevant.

Action is conceived at the same time as a micro-action, in the sense of resulting from the contingent meanings the actors attribute to their experiences, and as a macro-action, in the sense that there are structures which emerge from micro social processes and influence them. A distinction between micro and macro investigation levels is only made for study purposes (which are called “analytical” by Alexander). This theoretical approach is called “multi-dimensional,” as it considers action both normative (i.e. guided by norms) and instrumental (i.e. aimed at pursuing objectives), and ordered by means of structures internal and external to the actor. In virtue of its multidimensional nature, this approach does not involve the inconveniences of one-dimensional approaches, which conceive action as merely instrumental or merely normative. In the first case, action is determined or limited by external economic and political control sources, and the individuals’ possibility of controlling their own actions is not recognized.

In the second case, action is considered only normative, and therefore it is determined or limited by interiorized moral structures, which are an actor’s inner sources. This second point of view is unacceptable, as the first one, but for different reasons. In fact, in this case, the possibility that social order depends on external structures is ignored, regardless of individuals’ participation and consensus. In this connection, Alexander proposes a distinction between “action” and “agency,” which are both analytical categories, and consequently do not concretely exist. Action is defined by Alexander as the movement of persons, intended as actors, in time and space. Agency means actors’ freedom to move among the three structured environments of the social, the cultural, and the personality system. Action means, therefore, the exercise of this freedom – freedom of “agency,” in this case – by persons who act insofar as they are actors (Alexander 1998: 214–18).

Alexander argues that it is unacceptable to make use of an exclusively micro- or macro-sociological point of view. Both points of view do not sufficiently consider, in his opinion, the relevance of culture for a theory of

action. Like personality, culture should be intended, in this case, as an internal structure of action itself and as an actor's inner environment. On the contrary, society – intended as a system of roles, and hence, of norms and sanctions – forms the external environment to action (Alexander 1982, 1987a: 1–21, 281–5, 330–32; 1987b, 1988a, 1988b: 11–45, 304, 316–26; 1990b: 25–6; 1995: 119–23; 2003: 13–14; 1998a, 2009: 34–5; Alexander and Giesen 1987; Alexander and Colomy 1990; see also Turner and Colomy 1998).

A “thick” – that is to say, detailed and careful – description of contents and meanings, considered as unitary texts, which form an environment internal to action, and are socially shared and placed in their historical perspective characterizes the strong program of “cultural sociology.” A historical perspective has an interpretative or hermeneutic nature. This sociological research program assumes the autonomy of culture from any different determination (as classes or social structure). The strong program assumes, in addition, the capacity symbolic structures, which form the internal environment of action, have to provide non-cultural structures with meanings capable of giving individual and collective actors' actions a sense. Alexander aims at clearly distinguishing “cultural sociology” from the “weak” program, which belongs instead to the sphere of the sociology of culture. The weak program understands culture, and in particular the production of symbolic apparatuses, as a result, or an effect, of social structures or forces. These social structures and forces become therefore decisive, instead of being merely binding, for the social actors (Alexander 1984: 23; 1998: 216–17; 2005).

The Weak Program

Differently from the “strong” program, the “weak” program does not seek to make a sociological study of culture. Therefore it neither dwells on the environment internal to action (using Alexander's words), that is to say on the meanings actors attribute to their social life, nor does it explain which are the specific actors and the causal mechanisms, from which an alleged effect on culture results. It rather seeks to study culture as an environment external to action and as a dependent variable devoid of autonomy, and of an influence of its own. The social and institutional structure, social classes, and capitalism in general, can become the independent variable (Cordero et al. 2008: 529, 535). For those who pursue the “weak” program – like Parsons and the neo-institutionalist school – culture represents an external environment to action, rather than a context of meanings experienced and interpreted by the actors. In contrast with the “strong” program of cultural sociology, neither the independence of culture from social life, nor the dependence of its meanings on the local contexts in which it is produced are recognized (Alexander 1998: 216–21; 2003: 23).

Different sources have inspired the “weak” program, and each of them identifies a specific version of the “weak” program. Among these sources, Alexander points to some classic authors as Marx, Durkheim in his early works; Weber for some aspects of his thought; and Parsons. Classic are, in Alexander's opinion, those non-contemporary authors – especially the aforementioned ones – whose works receive particular consideration because contemporary sociologists – without any need of evidence – consider them as useful and illuminating as some more recent works, and even fundamental in particular social disciplines. Their importance for social sciences results from this general positive evaluation. Classic authors are able to make discussions easier as they focus them on questions considered relevant, provide the same standards of relevance, give legitimacy to new theoretical orientations, and formulate generalized theoretical discourses (Alexander 1987b).

This kind of discourse, in Alexander's terminology, involves a discussion made for interpretative or expository, rather than for explanatory, purposes. In this meaning of the word, discourse concerns the foundations of a discipline, that is to say, the epistemological presuppositions, the ideological and metaphysical implications, the conceptions of the world and the historical grounds of sociological argumentations, for the purpose of shedding light on the origins and the theoretical consequences of their disagreement. These discussions highlight cognitive and evaluative disagreements, which are recurring and unavoidable in the major perspectives of social sciences. In contrast with natural sciences, social sciences are interpretative disciplines. Each of them is oriented by different and competing fundamental presuppositions. Therefore, empirical validations do not put an end to these discussions (Alexander 1987b: 25–9; 1995: 122–3). Concerning in particular neofunctionalism, a “general discourse” highlights the problematic aspects of the

functionalism of Parsons and other theoreticians, whether individually considered or compared to each other. In the case of Parsons, in particular, the purpose consists in reconstructing, reviewing and reprocessing the conceptual apparatus and the theoretical nucleus of functionalist formulations, taking also the critical literature on Parsons, and functionalism in general, into account.

An Appraisal of Classic and Contemporary Authors According to the “Strong” Program

Alexander has devoted several monographic research works to an examination of the epistemological presuppositions, which have been adopted implicitly or explicitly by some outstanding authors. These authors are both classic (as Marx, Durkheim, Weber and Parsons) (Alexander 1982b, 1983a, 1983b, 2013), and contemporary (as Giddens and Habermas). For each of them, Alexander keeps to his personal epistemological approach, stressing on a number of occasions the overlapping and conflation of different analytical levels, and the theoretical reductionism resulting from them. Concerning Marx, Alexander remarks that this author proposed a merely instrumental solution to the problem of social order, as he made it depend on the power of the ruling classes, which rationally act for this purpose; but at the same time formulated a voluntaristic theory of change, according to which the revolution and the socialist society were the consequence of individual and non-instrumental actions.

However – Alexander argues – Marx has put the stress on external conditions as those determining individuals’ action and therefore not subject to their control. In this case too – as in the case of capitalism – individual action is subject to a coercive social order. Durkheim, as Marx, would have wavered in his work between an instrumental, determinist and individualistic vision of social order, and an opposite idealistic vision, according to which social order results from a general commitment to collective morality. The latter conception of order is produced by circumstances that are external to individuals, as it can be found in individual consciences. Both Marx and Durkheim have not made a sufficiently clear distinction between normative and instrumental actions, and between separate levels of analysis (Alexander 1982b: 61–77, 154–7, 203–10, 212–14, 292–6, 301–306, 461 note 202).

Weber is – according to Alexander – ambivalent in his evaluation of the consequences of modernity. For, on the one hand, his sociology is pervaded by “disillusionment and existential despair that psychological maturity and cultural integrity cannot be sustained”; but on the other, it points to the “increasing autonomy and strength of the individual,” which modernity has made possible (Alexander 2013: 31). These individual qualities are subservient to the person’s goal of self-control, but also to the mastery of a disenchanted and rational world. This mastering spirit, a consequence of this-worldly asceticism, is embodied in modern bureaucracy and politics. In turn, they have concurred to producing individuation, but also “the desire for voluntary subjection” and “a constant tendency for cynical adaptation to the demands of the day,” of which the “soullessness of modern politics” is a manifestation. Yielding to modernity’s “destructive, depersonalizing forces,” or confronting this tendency which represents modernity’s dark side, is a person’s “existential choice.”

Weber, however, does not explain how modernity’s “destructive moments can be overcome” (Alexander 2013: 43, 46, 50, 52). As to Parsons, his functionalism had the merit of reformulating Weber’s, Durkheim’s and Freud’s contribution in virtue of a merely analytical distinction among the personality, the society and the culture systems, but it neither shed light on the nature of values, nor did it aim at interpreting them. Furthermore, by identifying culture with consensus, and by viewing order as culturally guided, Parsons showed a normative reductionism. He also disregarded the “endemic strain” (Alexander 2013: 65) that follows from disregarding the value of justice. This hindered a broader conception of order (concerning the “reductionism” Alexander attributes to Parsons, see Camarda 1992: 403–406). Alexander’s neofunctionalist program of studies involves reconstructing and revising Parsons’ functionalism from different points of view.

First of all, any variance from a tendency to institutional differentiation has been considered. In addition, it has been avoided explaining change only in terms of strict systemic explanation, giving instead theoretical room to accidental factors, conflicts and social movements. Then, different effects of differentiation from those pointed out by Parsons have been considered, and it has not been maintained that such effects are necessarily beneficial to the single actors and to the social systems. Finally, Alexander has not followed

Parsons in the latter's conception that conceptual patterns reflect an objective reality, and values are the expression of institutionalized functional needs in particular roles that exist in the social world. Values have been understood, instead, as the result of an interpretation and analysis process of the meanings and the discourses produced by the social actors. Likewise, Alexander has not understood culture as a simple institutional regulating and control mechanism, as – according to Alexander – Parsons and other followers of the weak program have understood in the sociology of culture.

Based on the strong program, culture is instead considered as consisting of interconnected symbolic meanings resulting from typifications. During this process, the actors bring back the contingent aspects to structured forms of meanings, making use of the experiences they have achieved. Therefore, the actors do not limit themselves to passively responding to a pre-existing social order, but they define it symbolically, and acting in this way, they produce and reproduce it throughout their social life; they turn it into actions, and stabilize it. A sociological explanation implies a preliminary investigation on the interpretation of the meanings the actors give to what they do, to their collective representations, narrations and conceptual categories, and to the social consequences of those interpretations. Alexander also dwells on Parsons' evolutionary theory of modernity and societal community. He calls this theory Parsons' utopia, which is in keeping with Parsons' "ambivalence about order and normativity" (Alexander 2013: 66), according to Alexander.

By societal community, Parsons designates a society that has succeeded in connecting integration and justice, while refraining from following a non-normative orientation. A theory of social order, able to interpret and explain such a society, cannot include rationalistic utilitarianism or radical positivism. Alexander objects that there is a tension between integration and justice, as Parsons sees them. The evolutionary process of the social systems – "Parsons' major strategy for maintaining evolutionary optimism" (Alexander 2013: 72) – provides no solution to this tension. His notion of societal community is therefore ambiguous and unsatisfactory insofar as it sheds no light on contemporary major fears and dangers, such as the possibility of total destruction following a thermonuclear war. A more satisfactory theory of societal community would involve understanding and inquiring into the factors conducive to the dark side of modernity, and into the possibilities of civil repair (see Alexander 1983b: 51–4, 211, 272–6; 1984: 17–23; 1988b: 194–5, 281; 1990b: 4–6, 25–6; 1995: 120; 1998a: 61–73, 157–8, 165–74, 219–21; 2013: 62–77; Alexander and Colomy 1990: 44–55; 1994: 207; Alexander and Smith 2003. See also Reed 2009: 3).

Alexander affirms that, among these authors, only Max Weber has come close to a "multidimensional" conception of action and social order, making use in his historical sociological works, of causal explanations along with a sympathetic understanding of empirical phenomena, such as historical change and conflicts between social classes. A full acceptance of this conception has been hindered – in Alexander's opinion – by the lack in Weber of an explicit framework – at an analytical level of general presuppositions – that a "multidimensional" conception could be based on. Furthermore, Alexander thinks he sees ambivalence in this conception, as Weber supports from time to time either a materialist and instrumental epistemological position, or an idealist and normative stance in his works. Some passages in Weber's works seem to show discontinuity between his analysis of pre-modern societies, in which normative and instrumental elements are considered, and that of contemporary society, in which instead an instrumental and reductionist epistemological position prevails. This position would be illustrated by a number of examples in Weber's works.

If we consider, in particular, Weber's democratic theory, democracy is only a way – more effective than others – to assert the power of a nation state in a Darwinian struggle for ruling the world, rather than universal values and ideals. Similarly, a democratic competition among political leaders is simply a more effective instrument – compared to bureaucratic selection – for the task of leading a nation, because a leader's interest consists in meeting the needs of the electorate. According to Alexander, Weber's analysis of democracy suffers from reductionism. Alexander thinks he can identify the same kind of reductionism in other works of Weber, such as the essays on modern bureaucratic and judicial administrations, which Weber considers oppressive and effective instruments of power and regimentation, or in the treatment of inequality in status, which rests on the interest of the privileged social strata in preserving their privilege (Alexander 1983a: 16–19, 55–7, 98–127, 175–6; 1987).

Alexander makes an appraisal of contemporary authors as Blumer, Bourdieu, Coleman, Collins, Foucault, Garfinkel, Giddens, Goffman, Habermas and Mead, and of classic authors as Marx, Durkheim, Weber and Parsons, based on his epistemological presuppositions. He includes among the representatives of the "weak"

program, as well as Parsons and the contemporary authors we shall mention, also the ethnographic school of Birmingham, some institutionalist economy scientists as Commons and Veblen, some contemporary sociologists who focus on the cultural meanings contained in social networks, as Granovetter and other representatives of the new economic sociology, and finally, some non-Marxist structuralist authors, as Foucault in France, and Blau in the United States. All these authors, who can be considered representatives of the “weak” program, have not provided – in Alexander’s opinion – a satisfactory theoretical contribution.

We shall briefly mention in the following pages Alexander’s critical remarks in this regard. Focusing first our attention on Alexander’s reception of authors considered close to structuralism, the extremely critical nature of his essay on Bourdieu’s work is well known. In Alexander’s treatment, symbolic order (particularly referred to the concept of “habitus,” the vagueness of which is stressed), social order, and consequently actors’ practices are not placed by Bourdieu at the same level of theoretical importance, despite the author’s statement of intent. According to Bourdieu (in Alexander’s interpretation), social and cultural formations are external and pre-existing to social actors, but capable of determining their internal dispositions, and hence their habitus, regardless of the symbolic processes through which their identities are formed.

As illustrated by Bourdieu’s empirical studies on the French educational system or those on consumer choices and aesthetic preferences, the field of social forces the competition of which the habitus derives from, reflects, reproduces and is homologous to the capitalist social and economic environment in which it is situated, though not coinciding with it. Therefore these studies do not shed light on the specificities of the actors, the institutions and the social environments in general in which the actors act. In other words, they do not fully explain how decisions are made and the reproduction of society is kept in real social environments described in detail. Notwithstanding Alexander’s appreciation for the thick descriptions of some social and cultural environments provided by Bourdieu, these gaps turn into theoretical deficiencies. For example, Bourdieu does not consider it relevant whether political institutions are authoritative or democratic, as they all concur to the reproduction of power and inequality (Alexander 1995: 128–217; 2003: 18–19).

Alexander identifies the same epistemological and theoretical reductionism in Foucault’s work. He appreciates Foucault’s analyses of the ways in which discourses (as the author means this term) act to form knowledge and become power instruments, since knowledge and power, in his opinion, are closely connected to one another and to the social structure. However, Foucault does not consider culture according to Alexander’s strong program, that is to say, as an independent symbolic apparatus subject to actors’ interpretations and connected in different and contingent ways to the institutional apparatus. Foucault, on the contrary, considers culture, according to the weak program, as depending on the power structure. Alexander objects that the “discursive fields” do not have the internal homogeneity Foucault attributes to them, and they cannot be used to legitimize power to the extent affirmed by this author (Alexander 1995: 103; 1998a: 169; 2003: 19). Alexander formulates similar objections also to Giddens’ and Habermas’ work. In Giddens’ structuration theory, as in other works, this author neglects mentioning the cultural conditions through which the meaning structures actors learn and keep in their interaction are formed (Alexander 1987a: 378–9; 1988b: 311–12; 1998a: 213, 222; Reed and Alexander 2009: 37–8, note 8).

As to Habermas, communicative rationality, which is the key concept of his work, is, in Alexander’s opinion, culturally and institutionally connoted, since in modern societies, rationality requires a cultural mediation to become a relevant guide to action in any particular concrete case. The external moral and cultural order, according to Habermas, destroys interpersonal relations, which can no longer be informal and based on trust, due to the predominance of instrumental action over communicative action. Still, as Alexander remarks, the distinction between these two kinds of action can only be made for analysis purposes, because they concretely compenetrates each other. However, Alexander shares Habermas’ thesis that communicative rationality (overestimated by Habermas, according to Alexander) can and must be exerted by actors who mean to rationally control their communication, which is subject to being systematically twisted by the strains embedded in capitalism. In that case, the actors, insofar as they share the same life world, can consciously commit themselves to reducing the probability that communication is distorted without their fully realizing it (Habermas 1985, 1987a: 372; 1995: 118–19; 1998a: 169, 222).

The major representatives of symbolic interactionism have been closely examined, too. Mead, in particular, who is considered one of the founders of this perspective, has focused his analysis on the creation and interpretation of the meanings that take shape during or through interactive processes. These meanings

are contingent and are not predetermined, since they depend on a variety of actors' interpretations and answers to other actors' attitudes and significant gestures. All actors are bound by institutional constraints, which are both external and internal at the same time. Alexander argues that Mead presents sometimes the genesis of meanings as the joint result of the attitudes of some actors, and of the answers given by others, showing an empirical difference as if it were relevant to a theory of social order. This is not possible, because in that case meanings would depend on contingent and specific interactions. Therefore, in general, nothing could be said about the meanings, the cultural and material constraints, and the institutional and macro-sociological sources of social order (Alexander 1987a: 205–14; 1988b: 245–50; Alexander and Giesen 1987: 9–10).

Blumer's symbolic interactionism overemphasizes – according to Alexander – the position of a single social actor as an interpreter and creator of contingent meanings and attitudes, which are experienced and tested in the social world. In this case, though the existence of an order and of social structures, and consequently, of structured meanings is recognized, its origin and its revealing itself are not explained, as in general happens in the case of the individualistic theories of action. Blumer neither has, nor is consequently able to propose, a theory of society (Alexander 1987a: 215–27; 1988b: 250–53). As a further example of individualistic theory, and the problems resulting from it, Alexander mentions Homans' exchange theory (Alexander 1987a: 172–91, 216). Partly similar critical remarks are also formulated in the case of Goffman, who is considered the most outstanding representative of symbolic interactionism after Blumer (Alexander 1987a: 230). Goffman – Alexander argues – resumes Blumer's individualistic approach, and changes it by stressing its dramaturgical aspect. An insincere and manipulative actor, alienated from the social system and from cultural life, is placed at the center of the action. Alexander wonders whether social order is possible in such conditions, which seem instead to lead to disintegration.

Together with an individualistic conception of social order, Goffman introduces a completely opposite theory inspired by Durkheim and Parsons. According to this conception, the actors strive to keep a “front,” that is to say, a collective image and representation socially and culturally prescribed according to standards of propriety, dignity, opportunity, and so on. Goffman shows therefore a dualism and ambivalence between these two different conceptions of order. Empirical and theoretical strains result from them in all his works. In Alexander's opinion, this problem is entirely shared with the perspective of symbolic interactionism and results from its individualistic assumptions. Collins' work is an example of this approach. Collins, who is one of the most well-known contemporary representatives of symbolic interactionism, shows in his work an unresolved strain between a conception of the actor as a subject who willingly adopts a non-rational behavior, and a conception, in which, on the contrary, the actor rationally acts within predetermined situations to obtain unequally distributed material resources (Alexander 1988b: 35).

Though more favorable, his appraisal of Garfinkel's ethnomethodology is also critical. Alexander identifies a first and second period in Garfinkel's production. In the first period, Garfinkel conceives social order as the product of mutual adjustment processes between actors who have interiorized the rules that make it possible. Rules are the ways in which a system of activities is organized, and in this regard, Alexander quotes a passage of Garfinkel (Alexander 1988b: 237). However, already in this period, there is a basic ambivalence, since the products issuing from individual interactions cannot result at the same time from rules or other structural elements external to the actors. In the second period, this ambivalence is solved by a theoretical renunciation. Order is a consequence of actors' practices situated in specific organizational contexts. Actors' practices themselves form the rules, without making reference to rules or meanings external to these contexts any longer (Alexander 1987a: 259–61; 1988b: 233–45).

Finally, we would like to briefly mention the reception on Alexander's part of Coleman's work *Foundations of Social Theory* (1990). As Alexander notes, Coleman – and in general the Rational Choice Theory, which is fully enunciated in this work – shows a utilitarian – and consequently, reductive and reified – conception of the human beings and the social world, as if individual and collective action could be exhaustively explained by the single individuals' hedonistic calculation. An attempt to explain the meanings individuals give to their actions is deliberately lacking. This lack involves consequences of considerable theoretical relevance since, in Coleman's opinion, social order, and the mutual trust supporting it, result from rational calculations based on one's advantage, considering that only thus could actors meet their interests. Alexander objects that this individualistic solution to the problem of order is unacceptable, because collective interests are long-term interests, while the rationality of each actor is limited in time. As a consequence, it is not plausible

postulating that actors find some advantage in transferring their rights to collective structures in exchange for future benefits, and the existence of social norms and democratic institutions cannot be explained in this way (Alexander 1992b).

The Theory of Civil Society and Related Empirical Research

The empirical research carried out by Alexander, whether on his own or with collaborators, has conformed to his “strong” program. Therefore it has kept the distinction between different analytical levels, has identified the relevant actors, and has dwelt on the meanings and the social consequences of their actions, focusing in particular on civil society. This is a peculiar social sphere, limited in space and time, which in democratic societies penetrates and is interpenetrated by non-social spheres (or worlds), such as market, politics (as for example, democratic institutions like political parties, lobbies and associations), family, and cultural institutions as religion and science. Civil society is, at the same time, a utopian project and promise of integration and participation, as well as a normative idea of society. In the last two centuries, a large variety of interests and rights have made reference to the stock of meanings and practices that form civil society. This variety may be prejudicial to the compactness of civil society when the production of partial solidarities affects its overall solidarity.

This happens, in particular, when a tragic event of any origin permanently marks the collective conscience and memory of the group that has experienced it, because it creates or emphasizes the internal solidarity of the group, but prevents it from sympathetically participating in the sufferings experienced by other groups. While the common notion of trauma makes it directly result from particular tragic events experienced by individuals or collectivities, the sociological notion proposed by Alexander insists on assuming there is a cultural mediation among an event, the carrier group of those who have been affected by it, and a plurality of other subjects. In order to talk about a strictly “cultural trauma” not only must the group be persuaded that it has been traumatized by that event, but also others must be able to identify themselves with the group and symbolically and emotionally participate in the event in virtue of common linguistic, religious, legal codes, or codes of any other kind, to such an extent that the event loses a part of its emotional and identity call and finally becomes institutionalized (Alexander 2004a).

In civil society – thanks to the support provided by the public opinion and some institutions like press, associations, and legal institutions – as well as individual autonomy, cooperation and egalitarian spirit, trust and solidarity can assert and keep themselves. Solidarity is understood in a universalistic sense – without excluding particular individuals or collectivities – as widespread commitment in support of public interest. Public interest is defined so that it may have sense in the world of everyday life and among common persons. Nonetheless, a well-established civil society in its spirit and in its institutions is not sufficient to make the project of civil society be not merely utopian, as it must ensure, on the contrary, that democratic social life takes roots in individual consciences. A plurality of powers, separate and independent from each other, none of which should dominate the others, and a plurality of discourse communities and society projects, none of which should unconditionally prevail, are required for this purpose. In addition, free interactions among actors, who commit themselves to make up for conditions and circumstances incompatible with this utopian civil repair project, are also necessary (Alexander 2001: 587–9; 2006: 3–9, 31–6, 43–50, 194–5, 551; Cordero et al. 2008: 532).

Alexander argues there will always be exclusion towards some unwelcome social categories, such as particular ethnic and racial groups, religious minorities, criminals or psychopathic persons. Their exclusion, which may be institutionalized, is justified by the negative characteristics attributed to those who belong to these social categories. These characteristics, considered unbecoming or “polluting,” counter the favorable characteristics many members of a society attribute to themselves and to the group they belong to. Excluded social categories are considered socially impure, not deserving solidarity, and therefore unfit to participate in civil society and democratic life. The persons who belong to these categories deserve exclusion since they have one or more negative connotations resulting from their belonging: they are irrational, passionate, non-autonomous, deceitful, greedy, without any sense of honor, and inclined to pursue only their own interests.

The institutions polluted by these social categories are arbitrary, sectarian and prepared to favor only a few people rather than public interest.

In virtue of these binary categorizations, through which some categories of persons or collectivities are positively, and other ones negatively connoted, it is maintained in the discourses concerning society that some members incorporate the evil, that their participation in public life would therefore be detrimental to civil and political society, and that, consequently, keeping their exclusion is a matter of public interest. If these binary categorizations are institutionalized, civil society becomes internally fragmented and contradictory, and strength and violence are used against negatively connoted social and ethnic categories. This happened, for example, in the case of Germany's working class before World War I, and more recently, in South Africa, during apartheid, in the case of the black ethnic community (Alexander 2006: 265–8). A part of the public opinion supports and contributes to spread these representations of groups different from its own. In fact, public opinion mediates between the discourses made in civil society, and the institutionally regulated spheres of social life.

This happens in different ways: through the mass media as social solidarity creators or destroyers; through the creation of symbolic representations of collective feelings and the interpretation or construction of events; through opinion polls, which give the public a voice, even though manipulated, on matters of general interest; and finally, through civil associations, which formulate the matters to be submitted to the attention of the public opinion (Alexander 2006: 53–104). Alexander argues that democracy involves the existence of a fully developed democracy, independent of the state, and capable of exerting social power over it through its communication and regulatory institutions. The discourses that take place in civil society can legitimize and support, through appropriate ideological arguments, the inclusion or, vice versa, the exclusion of others in political society, based on their alleged suitability or "purity." Parties, which politically aggregate and represent different and contrasting arguments, or their leaders, make use of these discourses and ideological arguments to depict them as primitive persons because of their assumed inborn primeval characteristics. Their ideas and actions are therefore incompatible with the moral uprightness duty, and in general, with the moral and legal obligations deriving from one's belonging to civil society (Alexander 2006: 107–50, 193–5).

These obligations connect and, at the same time, divide the sphere of civil society from other social spheres. In the last 150 years, the boundaries among these spheres have become less sharp and more permeable, due to the growing differentiation and independence of civil society (Alexander 2006: 107–50). "Purity" or "contamination," as discriminating standards for one's belonging or non-belonging to civil and political society in which democratic institutions exist, became effective during the procedure that in 1972–74 led to President Nixon's resignation. Nixon had aroused public contempt for having committed or ordered (according to the public prosecutor) serious violations of the law. On several occasions Alexander dealt with the so-called "Watergate" scandal, which followed this indictment, and with Nixon's attempts to tamper in different ways with the evidences, pointing out the steps that drive a complex society as the American one to reconstruct its violated moral foundations (Alexander 2003: 141–5, 155–17; 2006: 142–3, 147–50).

The cultural aspect of the democratic systems is stressed by the legal and judicial institutions in the United States, with particular reference to the Civil Rights Act and its implementation, but it has neither been recognized by the sociological theory nor by the legal theory. Nonetheless, this is just the aspect that connects with the reasons, the relations, and the institutions that make civil society possible. Civil society cannot be considered focusing merely on the logical-formal and procedural aspects of laws, on the pragmatic aspects of negotiations and the coercive aspects of power. Laws, and especially constitutional laws, are of paramount importance as institutions regulating civil society and institutionalizing its democratic law systems and solidarity. In every differentiated and plural society, there is an unavoidable strain between behaviors characterized by solidarity, which assert themselves in civil society, and instrumental behaviors aimed at attaining economic efficiency in view of monetary advantages, which connote economic society.

Legal capacity to regulate civil society has been undermined by the exclusion of some categories of persons – especially women and non-white persons – from fully enjoying their civil and political rights. However, to make amends for the damage resulting from it, several civil repair procedures have been introduced. These procedures make use of the institutions in charge of communication and social regulation to spread and preserve a different and better image of the excluded categories, to provide them with a respectable, non-discrediting identity, thereby promoting their inclusion in civil society. Social movements

aim at achieving the purpose of those in whose name they act, succeed in turning from their isolation and public-discrediting identity to become members by full right of that society. Civil society would then lose its fragmentary nature, which is increased by the presence of several collective identities within it, and would gain in terms of solidarity (Alexander 2006: 193–234).

Examples of social movements are the feminist movements and the movement for the civil and political rights of the blacks in the United States. Alexander has examined in depth both social movements. The female gender was excluded from the civil sphere until the twentieth century, in the name of a binary code that confined it to the family sphere emphasizing its alleged moral inferiority compared to the male gender. A feminist point of view began to counter this binary code in the nineteenth century. Women would not have benefited from entering a civil sphere dominated by men in the name of their natural, moral and civil superiority. Throughout the 1970s and 1980s, a different feminist ideology began to spread, which claimed the complete equality of the two genders and made use, for this purpose, of universalistic arguments, which denied the existence of any inborn difference between them. Cultural differences resulted instead from the two genders' social construction processes. This issue ideologically paved the way for the full entry of the female gender in the sphere of social society (Alexander 2006: 235–63).

The movement for the rights of the American blacks is another example of institutionalized exclusion from civil society, followed by a civil repair and institutionalized inclusion process. This process could be accomplished thanks to the success of a social movement which had already set this goal in the 1960s. During the 1930s, a cautious change in this direction had already begun to emerge, though it was thwarted not only by a deeply rooted prejudice in the American society – which especially in the states of the South was dominated by the white population – about the blacks' moral, civil and intellectual inferiority; but also by the presence of a very united black civil society, separated from that of the whites. Black civil society was characterized by a strong ethical-religious imprint and by a complex network of communication and regulatory institutions, churches in particular. It professed values that were not different from those of the white civil society.

The success of the movement for the civil rights of the blacks can be explained, according to Alexander, as well as by the strong power of these churches to aggregate the black minority, by its universalistic and non-violent ideological message, which gained consensus and support also in the white public opinion and in the institutions that contributed to form and support it, for example the press in the north of the United States. Consensus and support can be also explained thanks to the political gifts of the preacher Martin Luther King, the charismatic leader of the movement, a personality with great appeal for the media. In his speeches, King stressed universalistic values of justice and non-violence referring to the Old and the New Testament, and claimed also for the blacks the enjoyment of civil and constitutional rights. He therefore succeeded in winning also quite a few whites to the cause of the movement (Alexander 2006: 264–316).

His appeal to inter-racial solidarity stirred the interest of many outstanding members of civil society, who urged a political reform and civil repair action for the black minority. This action was hindered in the south of the United States by the strong opposition of the white majority, the southern press, and the local political and legal authorities. The institutional support granted by the federal authorities and by the Supreme Court was, however, not enough to reach this goal. A direct action by King himself, by his sympathizers and followers, was therefore considered necessary. Some of them openly refused to obey the rules of apartheid, avoiding at the same time any violent action against the police or other authorities. This behavior was interpreted by hostile persons and institutions of the south as an arrogant challenge incompatible with the rules of civil society, and by others who lived in the north and were favorably disposed towards the blacks' cause – including the great press and the future President Kennedy – as worthy of admiration and identification.

Their support and the violent acts of the police against the blacks paved politically the way to the changes that took place in the following year, 1964, when the Congress passed the Civil Rights Act. The pursuit of this goal was hampered by some riots organized by the black minority, which the leaders of the movement were not able to control, which temporarily put the movement in a bad light to the eyes of the public opinion of the north. However, new acts of violence committed by the police, this time against children who were peacefully marching in the town of Birmingham, in the south of the country, not only led to the economic de-segregation of that town, but deeply and lastingly impressed the entire white public opinion in the United States, and urged President Kennedy to openly stand up for de-segregation in the name of the fundamental values of the American democracy. Thanks to this intertwining of political communication, inter-racial solidarity and

regulatory repair measures aimed at making up for the deficiencies of civil society, Martin Luther King had become a hero for both the blacks and the whites of the north.

The Civil Rights Act did not put an end to the politically disadvantaged condition of the blacks, because there was still no legal protection of their political rights. The volunteers from the north who did their utmost to guarantee these rights in the south ran serious dangers and in some cases were even killed. More effective proved the action of some black activists who for a long time had been fighting for their ethnic group, and already had a wide experience and a network of contacts. Their activism led to an extremely severe police repression in Alabama, which deeply shook the public opinion of the north and paved the way to the enactment, in 1965, of the Voting Rights Act, to the formulation of which the leaders of the movement gave their contribution as advisers. The Civil Rights Act and the Voting Rights Act, ratified by the Supreme Court, ensured effective protection against legal, political and economic discriminations to the black minority. Through the institutionalization of the civil and political rights of the black minority, and the subsequent legal measures for putting these rights into effect in social and economic life through the so-called Affirmative Action, the movement began to decline.

The radicalization of the movement in its political message, in the ethnic composition of its followers, and in the activities it carried out, which were successfully pursued by its leader Carmichael, also contributed to this outcome. The solidarity it sought did not include the white population. Therefore it became increasingly difficult to keep a large favorable audience and the support of the great press, though Martin Luther King was opposing this radicalization process. The inclusion of the blacks in the American civil society continued to be pursued also in the following decades. Nevertheless, the project of peaceful coexistence among different ethnic groups – called “multiculturalism” – has always been rejected by some militant intellectuals belonging to the black minority, because it would de facto ratify the whites’ domination, as well as by some conservative intellectuals, since this project would weaken the compactness of the American society. Alexander notices, paradoxically, a convergence between these critical positions, which move from opposite fronts, in their disownment of an American civil society that, though fragmented, does, however, exist in the United States and in other democratic countries as England and France.

Alexander declares his agreement in this regard, but points out the non-fulfillment of the utopian promise implied in the civil society project, and consequently, its fragmentations and limitations (Alexander 2006: 317–407). The concept of “common identity” is defined in different ways according to standards depending on specific historical, cultural and territorial conditions. These standards set some limits to a universal extension of civil society. In other words, there are always some categories which remain excluded from it, in actual and in moral terms. In democratic societies, legal instruments ensuring protection for these categories – as, for example, the prohibition of institutionalized discriminations in the United States and in India – and social movements, which act for the cause of the outcast and promote their assimilation, do not guarantee that their inclusion in civil society is actually achieved. There may be resistances on the part of opposite movements, in the name of a claimed primeval identity of those who are included in it. Their successful outcome might lead to symbolic and actual conflicts between those who are included and those who are excluded, and ultimately, to a deterioration of civil society.

Alexander dwells upon assimilation, hyphenation (or dual belonging) and multiculturalism, as typical inclusion forms of an ethnic group. Assimilation involves a declared abandonment of group identity. On any occasion in which a group must publicly show a collective identity, the identity of the leading group is favored, even if a subordinate group keeps its original identity. A significant example of assimilation in the United States concerns the black ethnic group after the enactment of the Civil Rights Act and the progresses in education and in the labor market that have followed it. Assimilation is unsteady and does not wipe out the stigma of the identity of a previously discriminated group, but confines it to the sphere of private life. Hyphenation may lead to greater tolerance towards a different ethnic group, which is therefore perceived as more acceptable and less “polluted” by primeval aspects incompatible with the dominant group.

However, this condition may also stir up hostile feelings against a particular group, and against immigrants in general, especially if diversity rests on racial standards. As a consequence, in this case the civil sphere is fragmented according to those standards. Finally, multiculturalism distinguishes itself from other inclusion methods for an attempt to purify, rather than remove, the unwelcome characteristics attributed to the different group. Its diversity is interpreted as a particular kind of the constitutive qualities of civil society, which is

fully acceptable and can be openly shown, and is proved by the actual possibility of marriage exchanges with the dominant group. Multiculturalism conflicts with the subordinate group's assimilation requests. These inclusions are mutually incompatible in civil society, in which the case of the Jewish religious group represents a significant example.

Alexander attentively examines this group, and consequently, anti-Semitism as a set of discrediting beliefs and exclusion practices against it. Alexander argues that Jews' assimilation and inclusion processes have never been completely accomplished. The Christian tradition has always refused to acknowledge to this religious minority – on grounds of the negative characteristics attributed to it – an ability and willingness to socially, culturally and institutionally participate in the Christians' society. The subsequent inclusion attempts made during the age of Enlightenment were hampered by a persistent anti-Semitism. According to a widespread opinion, Jews had to earn their integration by giving up their religious and cultural diversity, and by devoting themselves to some activities – such as agriculture – that would have withdrawn them from going in search of money profits, in order to start the process of their full participation in civil life.

Jews' emancipation from previous restrictions, whether legal or of another kind, was warmly supported not only by some intellectuals of the Age of Enlightenment but also by some spokesmen of the Jewish communities. The latter did not recommend giving up the Jewish religion, but instead Jews' full inclusion in the civil and political society. Those who followed Judaism in a traditional way and isolated themselves from public life did not enjoy their appreciation. However, this coveted emancipation could be only partly achieved. As a matter of fact, Jews, even those who converted, remained a religious group scorned and stigmatized as anti-social, which therefore did not deserve full participation in civil society. The so-called "Dreyfus Affair" – the judicial vicissitude of a Jewish captain of the French army unjustly charged with espionage in favor of Germany – pointed out how precarious Jews' emancipation was, not only in France. In other countries too, as for example in the Austro-Hungarian Empire and in the United States, we can find a number of evidences in literature, essays and biographies that bear witness of a strong presence of anti-Semitic prejudice.

Herzl's Zionist project represented a reaction to this ancestral, primeval antagonism against the Jews, as Alexander calls it. If inclusion is not possible, and on the contrary, it exacerbates anti-Semitism, then a withdrawal from the European civil society for the purpose of emigrating, or going back, to the Promised Land is advisable. The tragic experience of the Holocaust made the full inclusion of the Jewish people in the civil society of the Western world finally possible. In turn, the Holocaust was the result of an incomplete inclusion of the Jews in the civil societies of the Western world. Even in the United States, where the mythical image – supported by Hollywood films – of a free country, open to any religious creed and ethnic group, inclusion implied renouncing all Jewish peculiarities in the name of national solidarity. Many Jews were prepared to pay this symbolic price to legitimately participate in the public sphere, but new restrictions against immigrants in general, enforced immediately after the outbreak of World War I, stopped this project.

In the United States, during the period between World Wars I and II, the previous limitations on Jewish participation in universities, corporations, free professions and other institutions, went on. Alleged dangers that would have affected the civil society, due to the negative and indelible characteristics attributed to the Jews, were put forward as a justification, especially their tendency to act in concert in order to control the organizations in which they took part or worked. However, this justification became hardly tenable as soon as the foreign powers with which the United States were in conflict began to appeal to it, and the atrocities produced in those countries by anti-Semitism came to light after the war. In this new favorable cultural atmosphere, thanks also to the contribution of several essays and musical productions (in this connection, Alexander reminds us of the successful musical *Fiddler on the Roof*), the Jewish associations succeeded in mobilizing the American civil society in a joint effort aimed at fighting anti-Semitism.

Nonetheless, this effort did not prove fully successful, as a latent anti-Semitism, or in any case, an ambivalent attitude towards the Jews, who in turn are often ambivalent towards their Jewish identity, continued to persist in the American cultural and institutional reality. An analysis of some literary texts connoted by a Jewish background, as *Portnoy's Complaint* and other novels by Philip Roth, or movies like Woody Allen's *Annie Hall*, evidences the wish of these authors to depict the protagonists as persons who are clearly connoted as Jews and at the same time absolutely normal people from both a sociological and human viewpoint. A multicultural way is therefore proposed, though implicitly – as distinguished from assimilation – to incorporate Jews into American civil society as persons worthy of respect and affection. The tendency,

which is widespread among observant Jews and sometimes also among those Jews who are assimilated, to cultivate and publicly display the differences between Jews and Gentiles, conforms to multiculturalism.

Power and money – generally speaking, the accumulation of goods in non-civil spheres – may be instrumental in obtaining civil repair and recognition in the civil sphere. The boundary relations between these two spheres “can be conceived in terms of facilitating inputs, destructive intrusions, and civil repairs” (Alexander 2013: 135). To the extent that there is such a boundary, problems having quite a different nature are considered as either problems of the individuals, for whom institutionalized psychotherapy – “a central feature of modern life,” according to Alexander (2013: 140) – could provide the solution; or problems of society, which is therefore in need of civil repair. Alexander, in his most recent book concerning what he calls “the dark side of modernity” (2013), sets out not only to conceptualize this dark side, but also to suggest possible repairs. A number of undesirable features, or “strains,” connote this dark side.

They are as follows: impersonal and bureaucratic organizations, connoted by secrecy and elitism; commodification, at the expense of other social concerns; the uniformity created by the culture industry; lack of social ties and ensuing isolation; the demise of traditional communities; stigmatized identities; predatory nationalism and war; techno-scientific destruction of nature; finally, threats to the emotional coherence and stability of the modern self. Alexander puts forward specific suggestions to repair each of these social strains; for example, as to the social strain caused by isolation, technological devices such as Internet and Skype are mentioned as appropriate instruments to sustain long-distance communication. Modernity, the author concludes, can cause dangerous social strains, but can also repair them. Its effects are therefore ambivalent (Alexander 2013: 147–57).

The Reception of Alexander's Work

Alexander's reception has been critical in most cases. However, there have also been several favorable evaluations, and the critical remarks have often concerned different aspects of his work. Commentators have focused their attention both on Alexander's body of work, and on individual works, from the early essays on classic authors, as Marx, Durkheim and Weber, to Alexander's most recent work, *The Dark Side of Modernity* (2013). We shall therefore mention in this section the appraisals concerning his work in general, as well as those focusing on specific works and themes, leaving aside the reception of this last work by Alexander, on which evaluations have so far not yet come out. As regards general evaluations, the presence of positive and negative appraisals does not question in any case Alexander's relevance in contemporary sociological theory. It has been argued, on the one hand, that this author has contributed, more than Parsons or others, to an in-depth study of culture, of its elements of strain and the conditions that make a well-functioning society possible. Furthermore, Alexander's analysis of Parsons' theory of action, the distinction among the different levels of abstraction and the theorizations – from the metaphysical to the empirical environment – which have been used in social sciences, have been particularly appreciated. According to Alexander, these levels form a *continuum*, and consequently, any investigation in the sphere of social sciences must critically dwell upon each of them (Joas and Knöbl 2008: 9–10, 17–18).

There are, however, several critical remarks. The emphasis put on “discourses,” in the sense Alexander attributes to this term, does not contribute to Parsons' attempt to develop a conceptual pattern to be used for a functional analysis of the empirical world. The concept of neofunctionalism itself is generic and badly defined. Indeed, there is no agreement on what forms a system, though it is a key concept for this perspective (Joas and Knöbl 2008: 337–8; Turner and Colomy 1998: 57). The “strong program,” too, proposed by Alexander as a distinguishing element of his cultural sociology, has been subject to critical comments. It has been observed, in this connection, that Alexander is not always consistent in his distinction between the “strong” and the “weak” program; that the description of the latter is unsatisfactory and grotesque; and finally, that the distinction between welcomed social components of civil society and those rejected because considered polluting disregards the possibility that a group, or a cultural aspect, can meet with an ambivalent reaction escaping dichotomous contrapositions (Kurasawa 2004).

Emirbayer (2004, 2007) shows his appreciation for the “strong” program and Alexander's cultural sociology, especially as regards the thesis of its autonomy, and the investigation on the constitutive elements

of culture, as well as its relation with the social structure. However, this author remarks that quite often the “strong” program does not provide any indication on how precisely culture interacts with the socio-structural environment of action changing and being changed by it. In other words, whatever the causal direction, Alexander does not explain (his research on Watergate being an exception) which causal mechanisms intervene in the particular circumstances the study is focused on. Mouzelis, in his appraisal of Alexander’s work (Mouzelis 1999), advances some criticism, though, like Emirbayer, he seems to appreciate Alexander’s reformulation of Parsons’ conceptual apparatus. This reformulation keeps – Mouzelis argues – the distinction among the three systems (society, culture and personality), introduces a useful distinction between action and agency, and allows bypassing Parsons’ impoverished vision of the social actor as passively manipulated by his/her social and cultural environment. Nonetheless, Alexander does not explain which are the elements of the cultural environment, and how do they relate in general (not only in particular cases) to non-cultural environments. As to his conceptualization of civil society, Mouzelis remarks that, as in the past, there are still some particularistic forms of solidarity, which do not contribute to the solidarity connoting civil society, as defined by Alexander, and on the contrary, clash with it.

McLennan’s comments (2004, 2005) differ from the previous ones because of their strongly critical nature. The author observes, in the first place, that the “strong” program developed by the new sociology of science has insisted on sociological (non-cultural) explanations of scientific knowledge, differently from Alexander’s homonymous program. Secondly, Alexander has not made a clear distinction between cultural sociology and culture, because cultural sociology, too, does not mean to ignore the wider social context. In addition, the search for causal explanations of cultural phenomena does not relate to Alexander’s “strong” program but rather to the program of the new sociology of science. McLennan notes, in this regard, that it is not justifiable to consider the sphere of cultural phenomena separately from the sphere of social phenomena, as the autonomy of the former cannot be understood in that sense. Furthermore, the importance of sentiments and symbolic world in guiding conducts, which at first sight may seem considerable, should be evaluated from a historical-social perspective rather than being limited to appearances.

“Purity” or “contamination” standards to include or exclude some social categories would require a precise indication of what the author understands as pure or impure, since these designations are produced by a social construction. Alexander limits himself to a non-exhaustive discussion of these analytical categories. On the other hand, Alexander’s analytical category of “cultural trauma” represents a development compared to the historically undetermined use previously made of other categories. Moreover, McLellan wonders whether the study of cultural traumas is the only, or the main, field of activity of cultural sociology, whether that field does not actually refer to psychology rather than to sociology, and whether such a “trauma” could not be better investigated taking non-cultural factors into account, and particularly those of a political, social and economic nature. A critical evaluation of this analytical category leads McLellan to question the other conceptually connected category of “civil society.” According to Alexander, the category of civil society, if strong enough, would ensure protection against cultural traumas.

McLellan objects that the thesis expounded in the “strong program” is not sufficiently argued, because Alexander’s insistence on the relevance of values, rather than on other constitutive elements of civil society, is neither historically nor theoretically justified. Civil society, in Alexander’s opinion, is a utopian construction of thought, but the solution he provides to approach it – a multicultural society – is unsatisfactory, because in that case, a number of groups would be competing. Each group, in fact, tries to enforce its culture and identity, and to claim its rights in order to enjoy a part of material and social benefits. McLellan concludes that Alexander, by overemphasizing culture in his social analysis, has hampered his aspiration to formulate a multidimensional social theory. As mentioned, Alexander objects that McLellan has misunderstood him. In Alexander’s theoretical conception, culture as an environment internal to action has indeed only a relative autonomy from the social system, which constitutes its external environment. The interpretation of culture as an array of practices and beliefs requires placing an investigated cultural phenomenon – for example, the political crisis called “Watergate,” which led to President Nixon’s resignation – in its historical perspective, in order to come to a reconstruction of the meanings socially conferred to this object (Alexander 2005b).

We wish to mention here also some critical comments, published in the form of reviews, which concern specific works (books or chapters) written by Alexander. We shall begin from those comments, which were published first, notably the four books forming the *Theoretical Logic in Sociology*. Poggi (1983), dwelling

upon the first of them, notes that – despite some analogies with Parsons’ *Structure of Social Action*, especially the attempt to provide social sciences with conceptual and theoretical foundations – Alexander does not resume Parsons’ thesis of Marx’s, Durkheim’s and Weber’s convergence in outlining a theory of action; rather, he merely focuses on the two terms “action” and “order.” In Poggi’s opinion, these terms are not only key words in Parsons’ arguing, but also, in Alexander’s language, non-demonstrable presuppositions of the scientific process. Alexander’s discussion of these two terms, however, is unsatisfactory – according to Poggi – because the problem of action, but not that of order, is relevant both from an epistemological and a sociological point of view. Furthermore, the need to write other volumes can hardly be understood, since the problems of action and order are already exhaustively dealt with in the third chapter of this first volume. This third chapter – which is focused on the problems of action and social order – does not pave the way to subsequent books, as it seems to put an end to Alexander’s epistemological discussion.

The presentation and review of Alexander’s second volume (1982b) made by Wallace (1984) is oriented to criticism. Wallace extensively examines the first volume, and remarks, as Poggi does, the obscurity of the expression “theoretical logic.” This expression recurs in Alexander’s work and has great importance for the author, but – as the other key term “multi-dimensionality” – it is not clearly, consistently, or explicitly defined. Likewise, “presuppositions” is a polysemous term, since it can mean either “conceptual definition” or “empirical generalization.” Alexander does not seem to know this semantic difference. In addition, he does not explain the connection existing between the existential (presuppositions) and ethical (ideological orientations) statements that can be found in his work. The same ambiguity connotes also the conceptions of sociology and theory, which in Wallace’s opinion are expressed in an inconsistent and obscure way.

The interpretations of Marx and Durkheim, which take up the second volume, are questioned as follows: concerning Marx, an examination of his texts does not confirm at all Alexander’s thesis, according to which Marx, in the works of his maturity, would have removed any consideration for intentions and human creativity. As to Durkheim, Alexander affirms – in this case, too, clashing with Durkheim’s explicit statements – there has been no continuity in the thought of this thinker; as he thinks, on the contrary, to see some “antinomies” in them, which have no textual ground. A survey of Durkheim’s texts would instead reveal a strong thematic and conceptual continuity, in particular as regards some presuppositions of Durkheim’s thought. According to this author, beliefs and practices, together with the physical environment, contribute to form and preserve moral integration and social solidarity.

Collins considers the critical remarks addressed by Wallace and other commentators to *Theoretical Logic in Sociology* (the four volumes that jointly form Alexander’s first work) unjustified, though he has some reservations in this regard, too. In his review, he expresses a comprehensive evaluation of Alexander’s third and fourth volumes, which deal respectively with Weber and Parsons (Collins 1985). Collins gives a favorable opinion about the fourth volume, which he considers the most important work on Parsons ever published, and he appreciates the lucid style of Alexander’s formulation. In Collins’ opinion, the theme of multidimensionality and its nature and presence, or absence, in the classic authors he considers, are Alexander’s main concerns in all the four volumes.

Dwelling upon Weber, Collins considers him a multidimensional thinker, in the sense that materialistic (economic and political conditions) and idealistic elements (religious beliefs and normative prescriptions) combine in his works. If instead the term “multi-dimensional” means the simultaneous presence of a micro-sociological and a macro-sociological point of view, the former prevails in Weber’s methodological writings, whereas a macro-sociological point of view prevails, instead, in his historical works. Concerning Parsons, Collins reports and seems to share Alexander’s criticism of other commentators who would have mistaken Parsons’ analytical distinctions for empirical descriptions of the social reality. Collins raises instead some objections towards Parsons’ theory of social change in the presentation Alexander makes of it. Parsons proved to be a multidimensional thinker in formulating his conceptual pattern, Collins remarks, but his theory of change in terms of social differentiation is far less satisfactory than Alexander thinks. Multidimensionality does not constitute an epistemological principle, but rather a heuristic strategy aimed at investigating the empirical world in its different aspects – ideal, cultural, economic, political, etc. – and at obtaining theoretical teachings from it.

We consider now the appraisals of some individual essays or contributions written by Alexander, instead of his monographic works. The harsh criticism addressed by Alexander to Bourdieu’s work, as previously

mentioned, did not go unnoticed, considering the reputation of Bourdieu and Alexander himself. Lamont (1998) remarks that though Bourdieu actually exposes himself to Alexander's theoretical and normative criticism, the French author cannot be labeled as a neo-Marxist thinker at all, considering the influence Weber and Durkheim had on his thought. Alexander should have had to specify the elements of originality – if any – in Bourdieu's contribution and take other available appraisals into account. Concerning the "cultural trauma" thesis, Joas (2005) argues that a tragic event that has remained engraved in the collective memory of a group and, according to Alexander, has been socially constructed by it, is objective, and therefore it objectively exists from a sociological point of view.

Therefore, that event exists regardless of its social interpretation and construction, and its construction can be also made by persons or groups that did not directly experience it. Alexander would have conflated the investigation – surely useful – on the rise and spreading of the claim of having been submitted to a trauma with the presuppositions or the consequences of a psychological trauma on the single individuals. Finally, we wish to mention here an appraisal recently written by Emirbayer (2007) concerning Alexander's monographic work, *The Civil Sphere*, which we previously mentioned discussing its contribution to a theory of civil society. Emirbayer notes that this book reveals not only the ideas expressed by Alexander, but also those of the sociologists of his generation educated in the 1960s, and reflects similar discussions produced by the changes occurred in Eastern Europe after the fall of the Soviet Union.

In *The Civil Sphere*, Alexander's rejection of the cynic position, according to which rights result from power, leads him to study the institutional sources of mutual respect, civil solidarity and participative democracy. These sources are recognized in the existence of a vital civil society independent of political society. Emirbayer remarks, in this regard, that – notwithstanding Alexander's contribution to the literature on this theme – his theory of cultural codes neither considers the importance of emotions as a reason for solidarity, nor how relationships based on solidarity produce feelings of solidarity, the origin of which is not explained, nor what the boundaries of this "sphere" are; nor finally, why the symbolic aspects in the construction of civil society receive in his treatment greater importance than material aspects, for example money, organizational networks, and power. Further weaknesses identified in this work consist, among other things, in the attention paid to the history of incorporations in the civil sphere of American groups, rather than European ones, as well as the lack of an in-depth examination of the ways in which groups, whose identity is not consolidated, incorporate, and of the weaknesses of the multiculturalist idea.

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